



ShabbaTTogether

Mental Health Guide for Campus Shluchim PLAYBOOK

Introduction

For an increasing number of students, the college years are fraught with emotional challenges. This means that more than ever, Shluchim and Shluchos need to focus not only on students' spiritual growth, but also on their emotional well-being. This section outlines current trends in mental health and substance abuse among college students, recommends the appropriate role of the Shluchim and Shluchos, and offers steps to manage referrals to professionals when indicated.

Mental health among college students is a growing concern. Here are a few facts:¹

- Anxiety and depression now top the reasons that college students seek mental health services, with both of these concerns increasing over the past several years
- Research indicates that about **one in five** college students is affected by anxiety and depression; some studies show significantly higher statistics
- **Seven percent** of college students have contemplated suicide in the past year, and suicide is the third-leading cause of death on college campuses
- About **one in four** college students take psychotropic medication
- **Eighty-five percent** of students report feeling overwhelmed at some point during the school year

¹ Center for Collegiate Mental Health

Many reasons have been suggested for these alarming trends, including excessive use and abuse of social media, cyberbullying, and more. Our goal is not to analyze the roots of the problem but rather to help Shluchim and Shluchos identify and assist students with these or other mental health concerns, including relationship issues, family issues, grief, trauma, mood instability, gender identity, self-injury, and eating disorders.

Substance Abuse

Mental health condition and substance abuse often go hand in hand. Each has its own unique symptoms that impede a student's ability to function properly. When a mental health condition goes untreated, the substance abuse usually gets worse. And when alcohol or drug abuse increases, mental health conditions usually increase too. Following are recent statistics about alcohol and drug use pertaining to college students:

- According to a 2017 government study, among people ages 18-25²:
 - **Thirty-seven percent** reported heavy alcohol use; nearly 10% reported binge alcohol use
 - **Twenty-four percent** reported use of illegal drugs
 - **Seven percent** reported opioid misuse
 - **Seven percent** reported tranquilizer abuse
- About half of those who experience a mental illness during their lives will also experience a substance use disorder and vice versa.³

What is the Shliach's Role?

As a Shliach/Shlucha, you are a friend, rabbi/rebbetzin, mentor, educator, spiritual guide, listening ear, and trusted advisor. You are **not** (unless you are trained and licensed as such) a social worker, therapist, psychologist, psychiatrist, substance abuse counselor, or other mental health professional.

As much as you may wish to help a student struggling with emotional issues or substance abuse, or as much as that student expects you to help them, there is a limit to what you alone can accomplish. By overstepping your role, you are endangering both the student and yourself. The student is hurt by not getting the necessary professional help, and you could possibly face legal ramifications. Rather, your responsibility is to:

1. Cultivate relationships with mental health professionals
2. Destigmatize your students' need for help

² Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration

³ www.samhsa.gov

<https://www.drugabuse.gov/publications/research-reports/common-comorbidities-substance-use-disorder/s/part-1-connection-between-substance-use-disorders-mental-illness>

3. Identify students at risk
4. Refer them to the appropriate resource(s)
5. Continue to provide caring support and encouragement

The Importance of Self-Care

As a Shliach or Shlucha, it is important for you to look after your own mental health and well-being so that you can more effectively care for the people you work with. The concept of self-care is similar to the safety procedures on an aircraft that require you to fit your own oxygen mask before attending to others in the event of an emergency. By taking care of yourself, you can fulfill your role more effectively, maintain your confidence and achieve satisfaction from your work. Try to:

- Engage in activities that give you energy, lower your stress and contribute to your physical and emotional well-being
- Engage in ongoing peer-support
- Recognize when your physical or emotional well-being is compromised
- Seek intervention before your stress level gets too high

Warning Signs of Burnout

As a Shliach or Shlucha, the demands of your role can significantly affect your physical and emotional well-being. It is important for you to notice the signs of burnout before they overwhelm you and compromise your ability to effectively help others. Signs can include:

- Small issues produce strong emotional reactions
- Chronic low energy and exhaustion
- Getting sick more frequently
- Can't forgo perfection
- Having a sense of inefficacy
- Feeling overwhelmed and disengaged
- Enthusiasm for your work has faded

The Importance of Healthy Boundaries

As a Shaliach or Shlucha, people will be turning to you for guidance and support in times of personal crisis. People will come to rely on you and you will want to help everyone all of the time. Having guidelines, rules and limits will help you to identify safe

and acceptable ways for other people to behave towards you and will help you to respect the emotional and physical boundaries of the individuals you assist.

Proper self-care and maintaining healthy boundaries can also help to alleviate burnout.

Setting boundaries does not always come easily. To start setting your boundaries, consider these two categories:

Know Your Limits

- Determine what your emotional, physical, and spiritual boundaries are with individuals who turn to you for guidance.
 - Emotional - You may experience those who turn to you for help as vulnerable, manipulative, confrontational or selfish.
 - Physical - You may feel threatened or overburdened when people do not respect your personal space or value your time.
 - Spiritual - You may feel like your religious values are being compromised as you labor to help others.
- Examine past experiences where you felt discomfort, anger, resentment or frustration with an individual.

Be Assertive

- Inform others of your boundaries and alert them when your boundaries have been crossed.
- To avoid experiencing negative emotions and burnout consider limiting your availability.
- Seek guidance from peers and advisors when you suspect your boundaries have been crossed.

Pay Attention To Your Spouse and Children

As a Shliach or Shlucha, it is important that you recognize the affect your work is having on your spouse and children. Your family is susceptible to negative reactions and burnout, too.

Pay attention to signs of frustration, alienation, sadness, anger, resentment or exhaustion in your spouse or children and remember to attend to the well-being of your family while you care for the wellness of others.

Cultivate Relationships with Mental Health Professionals

- Develop a rapport with at least one mental health professional, such as a faculty member, a person in your community, or a family friend, who can help you navigate situations as they arise.
- Introduce yourself to the university's counseling, mental health, wellness, and substance abuse prevention staff. This is a mutually beneficial relationship; you can refer students to them, and in some cases, they may send students to you who would benefit from spiritual guidance or a Jewish community
- Some college health centers are better than others. When necessary, identify resources beyond the college where students can seek help.

RESOURCE FOR SHLUCHIM



Malka Blicblum is available as a **FREE resource** for all shluchim as a mental health professional. She is a certified professional addiction recovery coach (CPARC) and is available for confidential consults, referrals and guidance in any area of mental wellness. She **WILL NOT CHARGE FOR ONGOING SERVICES FOR SHLUCHIM!** She can be reached at 813-651-0201 or sbmdpa@aol.com.

Destigmatize Mental Health Conditions

Encourage students to take care of their emotional health and not to be embarrassed to seek professional help. Convey the message that just as it is accepted and praiseworthy to work out in a gym to strengthen one's body, or to seek medical attention for physical illness, it is normal and healthy to care for one's mental well-being.

*Include these messages in your speeches when applicable.

Recognize Students at Risk

In many cases, it is obvious when a student's issues are beyond your scope. Often, there is a "gray area." Learn to recognize early those who are at the highest risk and most vulnerable

- If a student is excessively needy or develops an unhealthy dependency upon you, it's time to guide them towards professional help.
- Don't wait until a situation escalates into a crisis.
- If a student does seem to be in crisis, help them get immediate attention.
- Contact the student's family if you are concerned.

- Improve your understanding of the issues by attending workshops or one-day training sessions in Mental Health First Aid or similar courses.
- Host your own **SafeTalk training**, provided FREE to Shluchim. Contact info@shabbattogether.com to schedule a **FREE** training.

Provide Continued Support

- After a referral, follow up with the student and, if appropriate without infringing on the student's confidentiality, the professional.
- Ask the student how you can help.
- Help can include: visiting; encouraging other students to visit; bringing food; staying in touch by phone or text.
- Continue to welcome the student to Chabad House, unless his/her behavior is disruptive or detrimental to others.

II. Academic Issues

Shluchim and Shluchos can play an important role in helping students succeed academically, and in many cases, you serve as the liaison between Jewish students and the university.

Your involvement can include:

- Educating the institution about Jewish holidays and practices
- Advocating on students' behalf
- Referring students to tutoring, financial aid, and other supportive services
- Helping students deal with faculty

Types of Issues

Students may turn to you with a host of issues. Aside from being a sympathetic ear, you need to know how and when to get involved, or where to refer them on campus for resolution. Sample issues include:

- My professor made anti-Semitic or anti-Israel comments
- I'm failing Anatomy & Physiology for the second time
- I missed a test on Yom Kippur and it will count towards my grade
- My grandmother passed away and I needed to miss a week of class

Establish Relationships

Whatever the issue at hand, the outcome is likely to be far better if you have already established a good rapport with the relevant college administrators and faculty. These could include the president, provost, vice-president for academic affairs, dean of students, department chairs, or other related positions on your particular campus.

Understanding the structure of your campus administration and knowing the players will also give you a better understanding of where to refer a student who comes to you with a problem. If you are unsure, a quick call to one of your contacts on campus can help you guide the student in the right direction.

Support Services

Familiarize yourself with the various services available to students, usually for free, on campus. These could include tutoring and other forms of academic support, academic advisement, financial aid, disability services, and more. The more familiar you are with services on your campus, the better your ability to guide students and to help them achieve their academic goals.

Jewish Calendar

Many students turn to Chabad for help with issues around absences for Yomim Tovim.

- Advise students to respectfully discuss holiday absences **well in advance** with their professors.
- Proactively inform the appropriate college officials each semester about Jewish holidays.
- Find out the state law in your location pertaining to religious absences, and send reminders about it to relevant college officials as needed. It is often included in the college catalogue.

Some Shluchim and Shluchos send a list of holidays and reprint of the state law to members of the administration each year. Click here for [sample](#).

General Guidelines

- Remember: there are two sides to every story, and you are probably hearing only one side.
- Encourage students to discuss issues directly with the faculty member first. If that doesn't work, refer the student to the chairperson of the department, and/or to the dean.
- Start lower on the chain of command; don't run to the president or vice president for every issue.
- For academic struggles, refer the student to tutoring or other support services.
- For personal or religious issues, when appropriate, send a respectful email explaining the facts to the faculty member, with a copy to the chairperson or dean.
- If indicated, ask the professor for a meeting, together with the student, to discuss the situation.
- Know when to step back. Avoid damaging your relationship with college officials. The student will be gone in a few years, at most, and you will still be there.

III. Career Referrals

At this important juncture in their lives, many students are focused on launching their careers, and often turn to Shluchim and Shluchos for referrals and guidance. Shluchim and Shluchos are wise not to underestimate the important role they can play in this area.

Many Shluchim and Shluchos have discovered that offering value to students beyond "spiritual" benefits is an excellent way to draw them in, and ultimately results in their becoming more involved in Chabad, either on campus or in the future.

Assisting students with career exploration, internships, and job placement is a win-win situation. It helps the student, solidifies your bond with them, and builds relationships with people to whom you refer them, such as alumni or community members.

Some Shluchim and Shluchos report that after they made job referrals, even if the students didn't attend Chabad events, they stayed in touch, asked the Shliach and Shlucha to play a role in life cycle events (wedding, baby namings, etc.), and became a supporter.

Here are a few suggestions:

- Reach out to people in your network and inquire if they are seeking interns or recent grads as employees.
- Cast a wide net, including family members, alumni, parents of students, doctors, attorneys, business owners, non-profits, and other Chabad organizations.
- Contact alumni, even those from before your time, to ask about internships. This is a good way to develop a rapport with alumni and to get your foot in the door.
- Invite successful alumni to campus to meet you and your students.
- Try to get commitments from local businesses, law firms, or organizations, to accept a certain number of interns you will recommend each semester.
- Consider launching a Chabad Club or similar group that offers internships with businesses or law firms as an incentive to students who attend a certain number of Shabbos meals or classes.
- Be sure to do your research, and recommend only students you stand behind.
- Before the end of the semester, sit down for coffee with individual graduating students to inquire about their future plans and how you might help.
 - Encourage them to join your alumni association
 - Talk to them about tzedakah
 - Refer them to the Shluchim and Shluchos in their new location

IV: Resources

Free Professional telephone support for Shluchim



Malka Blicblum is available as a **FREE resource** for all shluchim as a mental health professional. She is a certified professional addiction recovery coach (CPARC) and is available for confidential consults, referrals and guidance in any area of mental wellness. She WILL NOT CHARGE FOR ONGOING SERVICES FOR SHLUCHIM! She can be reached at 813-651-0201 or sbmdpa@aol.com.

Editable Resource Handout for Students:

[CLICK HERE to edit.](#)

Local Resources

Jewish Family Services, Recommended Clinics, Therapists, Psychiatrists, University Mental Health Programs.
Local NAMI Chapter Location: www.nami.org
Mental Health Resources Location: www.MentalHealth.gov
Psychology Today: Find Local Listings: www.psychologytoday.com/us/therapists

National Resources

The following are examples of the many resources available including those that support Jewish individuals and families. The RCJ does not endorse any of these organizations.

Mental Health National Alliance on Mental Illness (NAMI): www.nami.org Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA): www.samhsa.gov Mental Health Relief provides mental health referrals, education and support to the Jewish community worldwide: www.mentalhelp.org	Addiction 12 Steps Program: www.12steps.org Alcoholics Anonymous: www.aa.org JACS - Jewish Alcoholics, Chemical Dependency Support for Jewish alcoholics and chemically dependent persons and their families: 212-633-4600, jacs@jafna.org Anonim - Referrals, crisis intervention, education and awareness for substance abuse and addiction: 646-971-8222, www.anonim.org The Guard Your Eyes Network for Hum Recovery Assists those struggling with compulsive use of inappropriate materials and related behaviors.	Offers anonymous intervention, provider care referrals, 24 hour support, 12 step groups and more: www.guardyoureyes.com Family Member Support Al-Anon and Alateen: www.al-anon.org NAMI Family Members and Caregivers: www.nami.org Domestic Violence and Abuse Shalom Task Force - Dedicated to helping Jewish individuals and families struggling in troubled or abusive relationships. Confidential Anonymous Hotline: 718-327-3700 or 888-883-2323 https://www.shalomtaskforce.org
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Suicide Prevention
If you or someone you know is in an emergency, call 911 immediately.
National Suicide Prevention Lifeline at 800-273-TALK (8255) suicidepreventionlifeline.org

ShabbatTogether
www.ShabbatTogether.com

USEFUL LINKS

National Alliance on Mental Health

Learn the warning signs:

<https://www.nami.org/Learn-More/Know-the-Warning-Signs>

Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration
Information on mental health and substance abuse, hotlines and referrals:
<https://findtreatment.samhsa.gov/>

National Institute on Alcohol Abuse and Alcoholism
<https://www.niaaa.nih.gov/>

National Institute on Drug Abuse
www.drugabuse.gov

An excellent Jewish resource:
<https://www.refuathanefesh.org>

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